

Technical and Business Writing

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Writing Professional Emails



General Structure of an email



Subject Line

Concise description of your email purpose

Think ‘Why should I as a recipient open this email?’



Purpose

Why are you sending this email, phrased as a request



Impact (Optional)

What impact can their response have on you?

Optional, but most useful in situation where the requests does not have a clear or immediate impact



Action

What information do you need in their response?



Context (Optional)

Information to help them understand your situation and complete your request.

Optional and should be kept minimal if added. Include what is necessary

Updated E-mail

Some professors have **administrative assistants** that help manage their calendars. We found Professor Smith's admin's email on her *lab website* and CC'ed them. This makes scheduling easier.

This email is **purpose-first**, listing our meeting request in both the subject line and first paragraph. Since this email is long, we have utilized *line breaks* and *bolding* to highlight our request.

This section provides *additional context* (our research background) and the *impact of our request* (good fit for a PhD). This information is **optional**.

Professors are very busy, so scheduling a meeting can be difficult. We **include our availability** over a wide timeframe and *ask Professor Smith to choose a meeting time*. This decreases the number of back-and-forth emails needed to schedule a meeting.

This **information is optional**. If it is included, it should be relevant to the purpose of the email; e.g., only describe experiences relevant to the lab you are interested in.

We **named our attachment informatively** and chosen the *PDF format* as it is simplest to use.

To: janesmith@university.edu
CC: janesmithadminassistant@university.edu

Subject: Meeting to discuss rotation this fall

Dear Professor Smith,

I am a first year PhD student in the Biological Engineering Department interested in rotating in your lab. **Would you be available to meet to discuss your research and a potential rotation?**

Your research, particularly understanding how cancer immunotherapy treatment affects gut microbiome composition, aligns with my research experience and interests. I think your lab would be a great fit for my PhD.

Would you be able to meet sometime this month to discuss your lab's rotation process? I am available to meet Tuesdays and Thursdays from 1-4PM or Fridays 11AM-2PM. **Please let me know what time and date works best for you.**

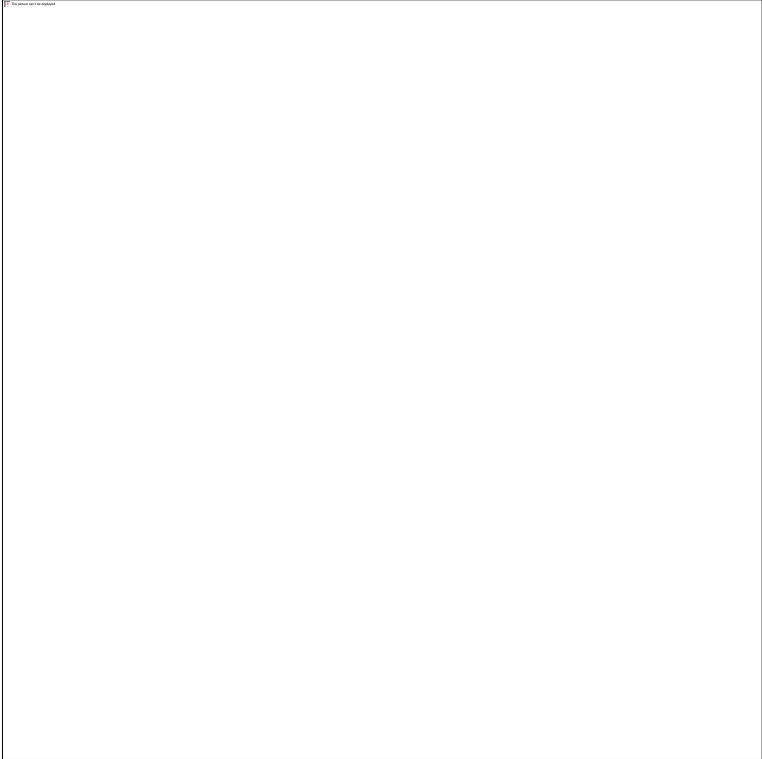
My research background is designing computational tools to assess changes in gut microbiome composition over time in breastfed versus formula fed infants. I am interested in continuing to study the gut microbiome, particularly on the bench using animal models.

Thank you for your time!

Sarah

ATTACHMENT: Sarah_Nemsick_CV (PDF)

Follow-up emails



- People are incredibly busy, so emails often don't get a response.
- This could be due to the email being missed, forgotten, or your request being unclear.
- Depending on the importance and time-sensitivity of your email, you may want to send a follow-up email.
- This serves as a gentle reminder of your original email.
- A follow-up email should be short and polite, reminding your recipient of your core request.

Sample Follow- up email

To: janesmith@university.edu

CC: janesmithadminassistant@university.edu

Dear Professor Smith,

I am following up on this email. Please let me know if you are available to meet and discuss a potential rotation in your lab.

Thanks!

Sarah

When to send a follow-up Email?



When determining whether to send a follow-up email, consider typical working hours.



Professors/professionals may not read emails received outside of working hours (9-5 Monday-Friday), on weekends, or on holidays.



An email sent Friday night may not receive a response until the following Wednesday.



For non-urgent emails, waiting 5-10 business days to send a follow-up is standard. For urgent emails, waiting 2-3 business days may be more appropriate.



Tips and tricks



Subject lines: Time sensitivity or Specific requests

[SIGNATURE REQUIRED] 20.000 course completion document

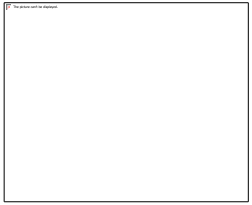
[TIME SENSITIVE] Lunch orders for group meeting 9/12

[DOCUMENT REQUIRED] BE progress report form

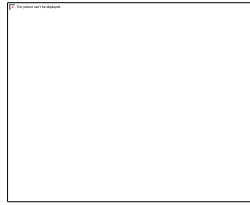
[DEADLINE: 9/12] Signups for faculty seminar

- Often time emails are time-sensitive or have a simple but important request (e.g. signature on a document).
- Consider including this information in brackets [LIKE SO] followed by your subject line:

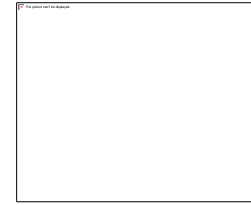
Confirmation of Email receipt



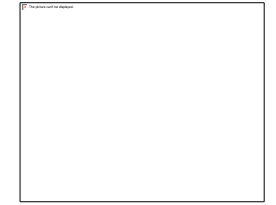
Some emails may not have a specific request that requires a response



For example, sending a professor a document they requested.



To verify if your recipient has seen your message, you can request a confirmation of receipt in your email:



“Please confirm when you have received this document.”

Text Formatting



Using **bolding**, underlines, and/or *italics* can be useful to emphasize key information within your email.



They should be used sparingly, if everything is bolded, nothing will be emphasized.



Avoid other formatting such as different fonts, text colors, etc..

Text Formatting

- Other text formatting options, such as indents, bullet points, and line breaks can also be used to create a more readable email.
- Numbered bullet points are particularly useful for emails which contain multiple requests.
- This allows your reader to keep track of each individual request and provides them a template to respond with:

To: alicelee@university.edu
Subject: [Time sensitive] Multilocus data questions + meeting request

Dear Dr. Lee,

Thanks for sending over the multilocus analysis data. I reviewed the datafiles, and I have a few questions:

1. What is the source genome for the sequence given as "genome4.fas"?
2. Do you have the original data files used to build the protein alignments in Figure 2?
3. Which program did you use to design the graph in Figure 3?
4. Would you be available to meet to discuss some new data this **Thursday, March 25, at 2 pm**? Please let me know by tomorrow afternoon if this is possible, so I can reserve the conference room.

Thanks,

Sarah



Hi Sarah,

1. The source genome is human (GRCh38)
2. I have attached the original files to this email.
3. I used R.
4. I have another meeting at 2PM, but I am available from 3PM onwards. Let me know if that works for you and what time/where we will be meeting.

Let me know if you have any other questions regarding the data.

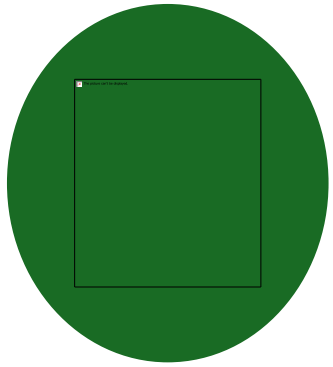
Best,
Alice

Addressing your recipient

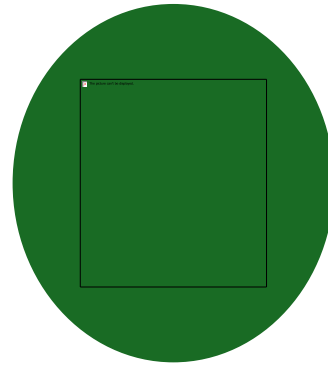
When you are not sure how the recipient likes to be addressed, always choose the side of too formal. Here are some titles you may encounter, in decreasing order of formality:

- Professor (Prof.)
- Doctor (Dr.) – used to refer to any individual with a PhD or equivalent doctorate degree (e.g., postdoctoral researcher)
- Mr./Ms. (avoid Mrs. Or Miss)

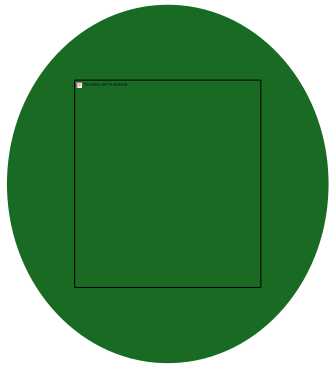
Addressing your recipient



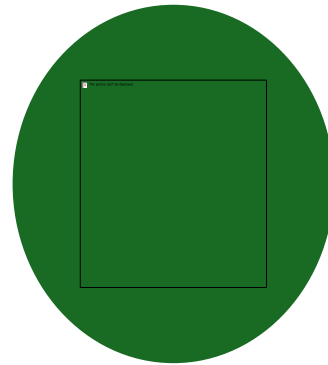
In situations where you don't know who the recipient is, make the best guess of their title.



Emailing for job applications – “Dear hiring manager” (if the posting does not contain a contact name)



Emailing fellowship organization – “Dear reviewing committee of XY fellowship”



General unknown recipient – “To whom it may concern”

A large orange circle is positioned on the left side of the slide, partially cut off by the edge. The text 'Email timing etiquette' is written in white, monospace-style font, stacked vertically within the circle.

Email timing etiquett e

Many people only read and respond to emails during normal working hours, 9AM-5PM Monday through Friday.

Unless you have an established relationship and know they will read your email outside of those hours, it is most respectful to send emails during that time period.

Non-urgent emails generally should not be sent outside of normal working hours, regardless of your relationship to the recipient.

When working with people in other time zones, try to send emails during the working hours of their time zone.